Same Same; Different Different: Universals, Commonality, Diversity and Variation In Parenting and Child Development

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I. The Scope of the Issue

- UNICEF considers children globally to be in crisis: political violence, climate change, and poverty affect many children (UNICEF, 2024a; 2024b).
- In this time of crisis, parenting is one crucial area of focus.
- According to UNICEF data, $\frac{1}{3}$ of children are subject to physical punishment (Ward et al., 2023); $\frac{2}{3}$ to some form of violent punishment (UNICEF, 2024a).
- In a review of 50 years of literature on physical punishment, Gershoff & Grogan-Kaylor (2016) connect physical punishment to poor mental health outcomes, and other poor outcomes over the life course. Ward et al. (2023) examines the relationship of multiple forms of parental discipline to child outcomes.

II. Are We Similar? Are We Different?



Figure 1: positive parenting

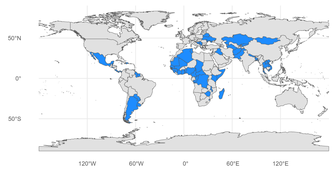


Figure 2: countries in UNICEF MICS Data

MICS data collected by UNICEF from Low and Middle Income Countries (LMIC) around the world.
$N = 224,632$ families; $N_{countries} = 60$
Contains questions about parental discipline (both positive and negative) and child aggression.

III. Highlighting Commonalities May Promote Intergroup Attitudes And Solidarity

"Hanel et al. (2019) cite research suggesting that 'highlighting similarities between groups improves interpersonal and intergroup attitudes.' Others have argued that 'build[ing] bonds of commonality across our differences' might be an impetus for social transformation (Hunt-Hendrix & Taylor, 2024)."

IV. The Argument

- Families, parents and children experience an incredible diversity of circumstances.
- Parents engage in parenting behaviors with consequent diversity, though with some surprising similarities.
- The associations of parenting with child outcomes are surprisingly consistent.

V. Parenting Behaviors Vary *Somewhat* Across Countries

Verbal reasoning and *shouting* are the most common parental discipline behaviors toward young children.

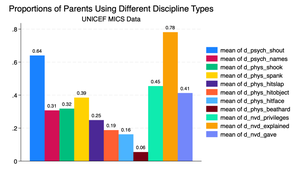


Figure 1: positive and negative parenting

VI. However, Outcomes Of Parenting Behaviors Are Consistent Across Countries

(a) Spanking in Country A (b) Spanking in Country B (c) Spanking in Country C

(d) Explaining in Country A (e) Explaining in Country B (f) Explaining in Country C

Figure 2: Parenting Behaviors (Figures created by Allison Liu, hiallisonliu@gmail.com)

VII. Why Is This Important?

"The current times are seeing changes at an arguably unprecedented rate, and often much for the worse–with Ahenakew et al. (2025) describing this confluence of challenges as a 'polycrisis'–including a failing response to climate change, capitulation to autocrats and divisive leaders, failures to adequately care for the poor and infirm, fear of immigrants and the Other, and many more. Responding to all of these issues requires some vision of common humanity to unite and motivate us, while also requiring an approach sensitive to local conditions and needs..." (Lomas, 2026)

VIII. To Summarize ...

- There is an incredible diversity across countries, especially LMIC's.
- However, the associations of different forms of parental discipline are surprisingly consistent.
  - Explaining to children the difference between right and wrong has consistently "good" outcomes in terms of aggression.
  - Spanking has consistently "bad" outcomes in terms of aggression.
  - Shouting has consistently "bad" outcomes in terms of aggression.
  - Name calling has consistently "bad" outcomes in terms of aggression.

IX. For More Information

Figure 3: Global Families Project

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